

to eat a cake made by me, a person who doesn't know the difference between sugar and salt.)

According to *Business Insider*, the average cost of a wedding in the United States in 2018 was more than \$33,000. (New York gets even more expensive, at \$76,000, and New Mexico is the cheapest average, at \$17,500.) Cultural affiliations can also up the cost. My friend Shradda, who had a gorgeous and large Indian wedding I attended in 2013, told me she spent \$90,000 on hers, which included the dinosaur-shaped ice luge I mentioned—nontraditional for the Indian culture). When I was flummoxed by that number, she said it was cheap for an Indian wedding. In its breakdown, the Knot, a very popular wedding website, notes that the venue is the most expensive aspect, averaging \$16,000 alone. Runners-up include the band (\$4,000 on average) and an engagement ring (\$6,000, which Allison assures me is on the low end). Two million people get married in this country every year. The wedding industry in the United States made \$51 billion in 2017.

In July 2015, Vox released a video documenting a couple, Isobel and Johnny Harris, who run a DC wedding photographer business, Simple Flare. The video revealed how booking the same venue for a “family gathering” versus a “wedding” results in a price difference of \$2,000. This is called “a wedding markup” or “wedding tax.” Queer YouTube couple Will and RJ, in a video about planning their wedding, similarly warned that as soon as you assign the word *wedding* to anything, the price is jacked way, way up. (They tried to mitigate this by hiring a wedding planner with connections who could maybe get them discounts, but that's a gamble.)

The Vox video posits that weddings are so expensive because of asymmetric information. The idea is that with many things you purchase, you're able to guess what is too expensive and what is reasonable based on experience. Familiarity allows both buyers and sellers to agree on a fair price, which the Vox video condescendingly called “economics 101.” (Okay, buddy. Chill.) But since this is most likely your first wedding, you have very little consumer experience in